

Why Me and Art?

No art materials lay around my house except for the box of crayons we had from school, now in pieces, and a few coloring books.

The public school in Spring Valley, Illinois offered occasional holiday craft projects, but no art classes for children.

My mother was a cellist by training and she also played piano beautifully. In addition, she was the choir director at church. She found an excellent piano teacher in the neighboring town and gave her time and budgeted money so Melisse and I could have piano lessons.

Playing piano and singing at church were enriching and enjoyable, but the visual arts were not really acknowledged as such.

One exception was the example set by my father who designed, built and painted all the life-sized figures for the Nativity Scene which he placed in front of the Congregational Church where he was the minister. They were handsomely done (including a camel and a few farm animals). He was a natural artist who was creating something needed for his Christmas message. However, that was the extent of his art activity.

When I was ten, I began to feel excited about drawing, the joy of drawing horses. I worked very hard to achieve a likeness, although I think my classmate Nora Schultz was getting a better result. It was a humbling attempt. Her horse was more of a farm horse, but it held together. I tended toward a Black Beauty horse, but could never resolve how to carry the lines through the hooves to a graceful result. Nevertheless, just doing this repeatedly and looking at my drawings made me feel elevated and I began to think of myself (and Nora) as artists. The teacher let us pin our drawings on the bulletin board.

We moved that summer to Alton, Illinois.

This was a fallow time in my art life until 9th grade in Alton when my friend Weebee (Elizabeth Sunderland), my role model in nearly everything, mentioned that she was enrolling in Studio Art. I did too. My dormant artist identity was awakened and I imagined a successful experience.

My attempt to achieve a vision of a night forest in flames (the image was emerging as I played around with oil paint on a large canvas) was at times elevating, but ultimately frustrating. I was disappointed in my result but not completely daunted. I had begun a new kind of dialogue with myself. I began to understand the gulf between intention and result. Weebee's piece was a colorful geometric head, almost like a stained-glass painting, impressive to me and to the instructor, but it didn't resonate with me as much as my own disappointing work did. What we love in art is quite personal.

High School years 10-12 took place in Oak Park, Illinois. Again, music took precedent over the visual arts. I sang in the acapella choir and learned to play guitar, enamored as I was with all the folk music I was listening to. I sang with friends Steve and Mark on the guitar and banjo in a trio

we named The Daybreakers, covering many of the songs by the Canadian singers, Ian and Sylvia. We auditioned for and got a monthlong engagement on weekends in May of our Senior year (1964). It was in Chicago's Old Town at a coffee house called The Fickle Pickle (sadly, no tape recordings survive!).

Oberlin, Ohio

I felt like I was going "Out East" to college as they say in the Midwest, but it was only two states in that direction. Oberlin College was another place for music-making with Freshman friends like Dan Lesnick, and Liz Ryan who also brought their guitars to school

Film students were making a movie on campus that year and I was asked to perform the song Cielito Lindo in a coffee house scene. (The movie Fantasticheria by Ian Shand and Mark Obenhaus has survived and is on Utube. My scene is about 40 minutes into the 1 hour movie.)

Also in my Freshman year, I registered for Art History, a survey of Art from Pre-history to the mid-1950's. I looked forward to each class, so novel was this subject to me who had only learned a little about Rembrandt, The Impressionists and Picasso. Art History opened a door for me, a whole world I discovered I could dive into and enjoy immensely.

Art History class was very important for another reason, I found sitting next to me in nearly every class an amusing and adorable guy whom I came to know as Rob Singer.

It wasn't until my Sophomore that we would spend so much time together, eventually getting married the summer before my Junior year and moving to Waltham, Massachusetts where he would begin graduate school at Brandeis in Developmental Biology and I would finish my undergraduate degree in Psychology, while also becoming parents to Benjamin Daniel Singer! He was a happy addition to our lives to be sure. Luckily, there was a nice family living on the floor below us with a little girl, who offered to babysit while I went back to classes.

I gravitated to the course on the History of Modern Art. This broadened my understanding and appreciation of many artists: Claude Monet, John Singer Sargent, Piet Mondrian, and Willem de Kooning to name a few. I felt a kinship with their take on the world and how they chose to render it. I began wishing to do more painting someday when I found the time.

I finished Brandeis with my degree in Psychology and a sweet two-year old-Ben in 1969. And I was elated that we were going to have another child in the coming year. I was looking forward to raising our family. Ironically, as I was beginning this life, a movement called Women's Liberation was just starting. Women were leaving the home for jobs and advanced degrees that would lead to a career. I had some ideas about a career in Psychology, but I couldn't contemplate it at this time of my young life with all the complications it would impose on our home.

Rob was finishing his PhD and excited to continue research at MIT on a postdoctoral fellowship. We were also moving into a bigger apartment on the second floor at 949 Washington St. in Newtonville.

I looked forward to painting and decorating our new home and making some small paintings for the walls. There was an art supply store a block away where I could buy some simple materials and play around with design. I was in the thick of home life.

“Benjy” started nursery school that Fall and there I met another mom who was able to car pool with me, Sue Beardsley. After we had become good friends, she and I took turns babysitting each other’s kids (we now had little Adam) one afternoon a week. I could now take my first Studio Art class at The Cambridge Center for Adult Education. I chose a Life Drawing class and later a Watercolor class which turned out to be abstract (I remember the instructor was challenging us to paint “depth”). These were important steps for me to not only develop skills, but to step into a real art studio. I felt like I had indeed found my “place”.

In 1972, Rob was finishing up his Postdoc at MIT and in the job search. He was offered a faculty position at the new UMass Medical School in Worcester. However, his lab was still under construction. To fill the “gap year”, he became interested in the possibility of another fellowship to do research at The Weizmann Institute in Rehovot, Israel. It worked out.

I was more than a little daunted at the major relocation, but in February of 1973, we took the boys and were delighted at the welcome we received at The Weizmann. Housing was provided and there was a ready-made group of friends, many of them visitors like ourselves.

Ben finished Kindergarten and all of first grade. Adam went to pre-school. They learned Hebrew. Good friends were made. We came to know our distant Israeli cousins the Gafni’s and The Nesviskys. My sister Rena came over for her Jr. year abroad and met Avner Porat while volunteering on his kibbutz. We all found our niche.

One of my new friends living in the apartment across from us was Rina Levitt. (Her son Reuven inspired our naming of our son). She and I bonded over our love of art. She was taking studio art classes at The Avni Institute in Tel Aviv a couple mornings a week, and she convinced me to join her. The instructors and I had very little of a common language but it did not seem to matter. I took an oil painting class and a watercolor class where we often took our materials down to the beach to record the colors we saw. The comradery and friends at the Institute was especially satisfying to me, living in a foreign country.

When we returned in June of 1974, Rob began to commute from Newtonville to Worcester, and search for a new home while also setting up his lab.

On October 3rd, we moved from the Boston area to the “country”, 55 Holman Street, Shrewsbury. Rob had convinced the realtor to let him look at an old farmhouse near Shrewsbury Center. She agreed to show it, but told him, “Your wife will not like it: it’s never been remodeled.” When I came to see it, that’s what I loved about it, a place that echoed the homes of my grandparents, a home that was built by an old Shrewsbury family. It became our family home, a place that has always inspired me.

There was plenty of land and a barn for the boys to explore, and happily, other young families in the neighborhood. It wasn’t long before Reuven joined us, making our family complete.

When we were settled in Shrewsbury, I found The Worcester Art Museum. Outside of home, this would become my new anchor. I volunteered there, took many of the classes offered, and made acquaintance with the art staff, some of whom became my friends.

My first class was outdoor landscaping painting in Green Hill Park taught by Robert Grady. He showed me that one need only use some shellac on a paper from a grocery bag to create a durable surface for painting. A few of my early landscapes (scenes from around my yard) were painted on shellacked paper taped to a piece of cardboard on my easel. They still look fresh almost 50 years later.

I took a portrait painting class with Robert Douglas Hunter, an old gentleman from Boston's Back Bay who demonstrated oil painting in a 3-piece suit.

I enjoyed Winslow Myers drawing and design class. He helped me expand on ideas he presented. I brought in work I had done at home for his feedback, and began to assemble a portfolio as a result.

A well-known Worcester artist, Terri Priest, taught color theory and silk-screen printmaking. Understanding the color wheel and how colors affect each other was basic and important. Silk screen was quite technical which impressed me, but I didn't find the multistep process enjoyable. Terri also would critique for me pieces I brought in.

Since I was doing more artwork at home, Rob suggested that we make a studio upstairs in the barn by installing a skylight on the North side. This was pretty exciting for me - to go up there and see the beautiful light filtering in, to have room to build canvases of a larger size and begin painting large abstract paintings. I also applied layers of gesso to heavy paper for smaller oil paintings I would frame under glass. I built frames too.

When it got too cold to work there, I created another studio space in our third floor attic, by insulating it and installing special lighting that would simulate natural light.

I began to enter some juried art exhibits with the encouragement of my art mentors. I'd have to frame and deliver my work to places like Springfield, MA, or New Canaan CT and then wait to see if I got a postcard notifying me that my piece was chosen for the show. I was so happy when I began to receive some acceptances, in some cases an honorable mention. Then I'd want to go to the opening to see my picture hanging in the show. Finally, I had to retrieve it because it had not sold or I chose not to sell it.

I also applied for and had the chance to mount exhibits in a number of college art galleries in the Worcester and Boston areas (Emmanuel, St. Regis, WPI, Quinsigamond CC, St. Mark's Prep, UMass). In this way I became part of the Worcester art community and friendly with quite a few area artists: Peter Nelson (whose large canvas hangs in our New York apartment), Robert Thorn, Cheryl Griffiths and Sally Bishop, who introduced me to Sue Swinand, an enduring friend. We would attend each other's openings and meet up at group shows. We were founding members of Arts Worcester, an association which promotes the whole enterprise of artmaking in Worcester and has a gallery downtown.

In 1986, I decided to enroll in a painting class at UMass in Amherst which meant driving there two afternoons a week. I wanted to become acquainted with their Art department and

ultimately apply for an MFA in the graduate program. It felt like the challenge I needed and a confirmation of my choice to be an artist.

I enjoyed the painting classes, but ultimately my application was not successful. UMass was admitting only six painting students and the professor who knew me by then told me that my work was very good, but I did not have a strong enough individual “voice” to be accepted into their program. I couldn’t argue with that; Art is so subjective. However, maybe the committee was right. I wasn’t striving to introduce anything New to the world.

Although disappointed, I felt some relief. Going to school in Amherst would cut into my family time, so it was perhaps not realistic either.

From that time on, I decided that I did not care to paint for exhibition only. I had achieved that goal and had been finding that kind of art-making to be self-absorbing and isolating, constantly focusing on my own image-making for the next show.

Instead, I decided to paint for my own satisfaction. I turned back to the world outside my studio, the New England landscape. I arranged my garden flowers into still lifes and painted them in acrylic paint. I took watercolors outdoors and studied the stateliness and elegance of trees. There was more joy in what I was doing. I was invited to show some of my new pieces in a local show and found a warmer response, not surprisingly.

I also began to think about using my psychology background to help others. It seemed logical to combine my interests and learn more about Art Therapy. I found a way to volunteer at The Worcester Youth Guidance Center by contacting the director and asking if they used Art Therapy there. There was an Art Therapist on the staff named Susan Tritell who was also a practicing psychotherapist. I decided to contact her and ask if I could talk with her about the field of Art Therapy. She was very encouraging for me to take steps to get involved. Her suggestion was that I begin by volunteering at the agency in the waiting room where children were waiting for family members who were in appointments. I could set up a drawing table and inviting them to join me. Afterwards, I would process the art with her and see what we could deduce from the drawings. This worked out as planned and I had a productive year.

Susan was kind enough to support my application to the Master’s program in Expressive Arts Therapies at Lesley College in Cambridge. And with my portfolio and Psychology degree, I was accepted for the Fall of 1988.

After internships with the Worcester Youth Guidance Center and at the RFK Children’s Action Corps in Lancaster, MA, I joined the staff in the Adolescent Unit at RFK.

My experience there was rich in learning and made me glad that I had entered this field in order to understand more about mental health diagnoses and how to treat them. I didn’t abandon making art, but I did gain satisfaction from helping others use art to aid in their treatment. I kept my own art materials nearby, however, reminding me to practice my own “art therapy”.

Six years at RFK and we had an empty nest at home. Rob was offered the Chair of the Anatomy Department at Albert Einstein College of Medicine. After 20 years at UMass, he welcomed the chance to move to the New York world of science.

I was able to join the Psychiatry Department using Art Therapy in a day treatment program for adults where I worked for 12 years. Commuting to the Bronx daily and immersing myself in the community there was another wonderful benefit of choosing this path.

New York was a rich place to enjoy Art. We were lucky to access all the Fine Art museums within walking distance of our new apartment on E. 84th St.: The MET, the Guggenheim, The Whitney, The Frick, The Jewish Museum, the Cooper Hewitt Museum and many art galleries. Years of looking at art in NY sharpened my “eye” and deepened my appreciation of classical and modern art.

In New York, my art studio was condensed into a backpack of watercolor supplies and paper. I painted in various corners of Central Park, on my international and domestic travels with Rob, or on weekends back home in Shrewsbury. I enjoyed working on small pieces en plein air, as they call outdoor painting.

Although I have been doing this for so long, I still feel like anything could happen when I begin a painting. It always surprises me. That’s the experience and the allure of art. It always feels new.

It seems likely that a discerning eye, or eyes that like to look and examine, combined with the ability to translate that into a drawing can be a family trait. A number of people in my father’s family were inclined toward art-making. I think that’s where I got the interest to start with. It has shown up in all the generations of our family (the ability enhanced by in-law traits as well) and continues with my children and grandchildren. I’m very happy to see interesting art emerge from this grandchild or that one. I know they have found something that will always be with them.

Not everyone has the time or opportunity to develop their skills. If one has a wish to, however, he or she should not be shy about trying. Lessons aren’t needed, just the desire to experiment with simple art materials and see where it goes. The learning is in the doing. Making art relaxes the busy side of the brain and gives one a little break. Time passes as one becomes absorbed in the process. And then, you have created a memory from a moment in time.

I would like to thank Rob for always supporting and appreciating my artwork. His mother loved Art History and was also was a painter. Art was valued as an important part of life. I am grateful that these became his values also.

Amy Singer, June 2026

